EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

Why Put a Soul in a Body?

Emunot VeDeot, Essay 6:4-5

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

Essay/Chapters: Essay 6 (The Soul), Chapters 4 and 5

Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 17 March 2025, on Zoom

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: What the Soul Is

The first shiur after Purim. The plan: Chapters 4 and 5 tonight; Chapters 6 and 7 next week, at 6:45 ("the final week before the clocks change"); and Chapter 8, the last of the essay, the week after, before a break for Pesach.

- **Chapter 1:** what the *nefesh* is **not**: not an accidental by-product of the body, not air, not fire, not two kinds of air, and not the blood, as **Anan** thought.
- **Chapter 2:** why Saadia went through the other opinions: understanding the soul is complex and subtle. Hence **מי יודע**, "who knows" the subtle difference between lofty and lowly souls.
- **Chapter 3:** Saadia's seven points:
- The soul is **created**, not eternal.
- It is created **simultaneously with the body**. There is no warehouse of souls, "which immediately, by the way, will negate the whole concept of *gilgulim*," to come in Chapter 8.
- It is **lofty and ethereal**, finer than the spheres, since it has intellect and (for Saadia, unlike the Rambam) the spheres do not.
- It is **independently wise**, not dependent on the body.
- It **only works together with the body**.
- There is **one soul with different faculties**, hence its names: *nefesh* for desire, *ruach* for emotion, *neshamah* for intellect, *chayah* because it lives eternally, *yechidah* because it is unique. The Rambam says the same, with five faculties.
- It **dwells in the heart**.

"These two chapters, we're going to do quickly. They're pretty straightforward."

Chapter 4: Why Would God Put a Lofty Soul in a Lowly Body?

Having shown that the soul is lofty, ethereal and unique, finer even than the spheres, Saadia takes up the question people ask: **why would HaKadosh Baruch Hu join it to something as lowly as the human body?** People conclude that God is doing the soul a wrong.

Step 1: God does no wrong

A general principle. From Essays 1 and 2, it is impossible to believe God would do wrong to any of His creatures. He does not need them; He gives them their very being. And God is entirely good: one of Saadia's main answers to why God created the universe was **to bestow goodness**. Why would He create the soul in order to harm it?

A specific argument. People do harm for **one of three reasons**, "and there's no fourth reason." When anyone has ever done you harm, it came from one of these:

	Why people do harm	Why it cannot apply to God
1	**Fear**: he is afraid you will hurt him, so he attacks first	God fears no one
2	**Desire**: you have something he wants, money or belongings	God desires nothing
3	**Ignorance**: he misunderstands the nature of something	God knows everything

Saadia finds all three in one verse:

אשר לא נשא פני שרים ולא נכר שוע לפני דל כי מעשה ידיו כלם (Iyov 34:19)

- **"He does not favour princes"**: people favour the powerful because they fear them; He fears no one.
- **"He does not prefer the rich over the poor"**: people favour the wealthy because they want their wealth; He wants nothing.
- **"For they are all the work of His hands"**: having made them all, He knows them all and all their actions.

Step 2: The soul cannot function alone

Fine, God is not harming the soul. But why join them? Because **that is the nature of the soul: it cannot function alone.** It must be joined to something in order to be active, and only by being active can it reach **eternal bliss**.

When a person does good, the soul gains light; when he sins, it is darkened. **אור זרע לצדיק**, light is sown for the righteous: the soul is illuminated, while one who goes astray is shadowed, darkened, lost.

"When we say *we*... we're talking about the *guf* and the *nefesh* together." For Saadia, as these chapters show "black and white," body and soul act as one. The *nefesh* directs and the body is its vehicle, but a human's good deed is the deed of both together.

Refining silver and gold

Hashem examines whether the soul does good or bad. Saadia compares this to **refining silver and gold in fire**: the precious metal remains and the dross is burnt away. "The Chachamim did the same, by the way. They always liked this analogy."

וצרפתים כצרף את הכסף, "I will refine them as silver is refined."

בחנני כזהב אצא, "test me, and I shall come out like gold."

- But those that keep their dross are **כסף נמאס**, "rejected silver," and will not have great bliss in the future.

Even a soul with impurities can still purify itself. That is teshuvah, possible as long as one is alive. "Once your soul leaves your body at death, then there's no more hope. But whilst the soul is still active together with the body, there is hope."

Step 3: Then why not leave the soul alone?

Wouldn't it be better if God simply created the soul and left it alone, free of the body?

No: **alone, it would not reach bliss**, because it only reaches eternal bliss by working with the body and **choosing good**. "Just like fire can only work together with something combustible." Without something to burn, there is no fire.

And without each other, **neither is functional**. When we die, the body without the soul is nothing; the soul without the body cannot act. Then there would be no point to creating them, and no point to the universe, because, as Saadia argued at the start of the free will essay and as the start of Bereishit shows, **the universe was created for the human being**.

Step 4: Then why not give the soul a different nature?

Why not create a soul that can attain goodness **without** being joined to a body?

Saadia answers with a principle he has used many times: this is like asking why God did not make **a human being with the powers of the angels**. "That's no longer a human. You're asking that a man won't be a man and a soul won't be a soul." A soul that worked alone would be something else, a sphere, an angel. "Beautiful words." It is like saying, "I like fire, but I want fire to go down; I want water to go up," or wanting fire to cool and snow to warm. You are asking for them not to be fire and water.

Those who ask this "are completely perverting intellect," Saadia says. **True wisdom is for things to be according to their essence.**

The Rabbi singled this out: "This is a line which nowadays people would do good to remember. Look at this key line here." Wisdom is not defined by how a person wants it to be. "Many of the problems of the world which we live in nowadays stem from a lack of understanding of this one line in Saadia. People want biology, they want nature, they want science to be according to the way they want it to be. No. Facts are facts. Wisdom is wisdom." Or as Yeshayahu puts it, **היאמר חמר ליצרו מה תעשה**, "shall the clay say to its Maker, what are you doing?"

A participant summed it up: the channel of bliss for the soul is **action**, mitzvot, and action needs a body. "That's precisely what it is. You summarised what he said."

Step 5: Why then does the soul suffer?

If God wants only good for the soul, why does it sin and suffer?

- **It chooses to: אשר עשה האלהים את האדם ישר והמה בקשו חשבנות רבים**, "God made man upright, but they sought many schemes."

Step 6: Is the body really impure?

"This is fascinating." Even granting all that, isn't the soul still mixed with something **impure**, the body?

Saadia rejects the premise. "Very different to how we are often taught," especially in Kabbalistic literature, that the body is inherently bad and the soul inherently good.

- **The human body is pure at its core.**
- **Impurity (*tumah*) is not something rational**, so one cannot extend it by reasoning to places the Torah did not.
- The Torah makes only certain **emissions** of the body impure, and only once they are emitted. While they are within the person, they do not make him impure.
- Those who say otherwise "are making up their own Torah, and want us to accept it. We're not going to accept that."

So part of the question, why put the lofty soul in a *lowly* body, falls away: who said the body is lowly? "True, the body is not like the soul. Accept that. But don't tell me the body is this kind of impure, terrible thing."

The German pietists. The Rabbi contrasted this with the medieval **Chassidei Ashkenaz**, whose literature, he said, "you'll be shocked to read": a self-flagellating negation of the body, rolling in snow to deaden the body's feeling, letting bees sting them. "It's literally in *Sefer HaRokeach* and *Sefer Chassidim*... because the body is bad and we have to negate the body. There's none of that in Saadia."

Why is a dead body impure, then?

The greatest impurity is a corpse. On Saadia's principle, that is because **there has been an emission: the departure of the soul**. Tumah is essentially a **vacuum**; when a person dies, the body is emptied of its soul.

The **Or HaChaim**, Rabbi Chaim ben Attar, some 250 years ago, uses this to explain why only Jewish bodies convey impurity: in his very Kabbalistic understanding, the soul of a Jew differs from that of a non-Jew, so its departure leaves a greater vacuum. "I don't think Saadia would agree. Certainly the Rambam wouldn't agree."

Halachically, by the strict halachah of the Shulchan Aruch and certainly of the Sephardi authorities, **a Kohen may touch non-Jewish bodies and walk in non-Jewish cemeteries**. The Rabbi mentioned the episode "a year or so ago" when Chassidim in Stamford Hill petitioned for a special route avoiding the Science Museum in South Kensington, which connects to the tube station and holds many human bones. "Misplaced, in my humble opinion. If you want to be *machmir*, that's great, but it's a *chumrah*. The halachah is that a non-Jewish body does not make a Kohen impure."

Two reasons a soul suffers

Saadia closes the chapter:

1. **Its own sins.** Like a person who goes out in the cold and then asks why he is ill: it is his own fault. **ערום ראה רעה ונסתר ופתיים עברו ונענשו**, "the prudent see trouble and hide; the simple go on and suffer for it." The soul has been given the choice.
2. **To do it good in the future**, as discussed in previous essays: to test it and raise it up. **אשרי הגבר אשר תיסרנו יה**, "happy is the man whom You chasten."

Summary of Chapter 4

Question	Answer
Is God harming the soul by putting it in a body?	No. God does no harm; people harm out of fear, desire or ignorance, none of which applies to Him
Then why join them?	The soul **cannot function alone**; only by acting and choosing good through the body can it gain light and eternal bliss
Why not leave it alone?	Alone it is non-functional, the body is non-functional, and the universe loses its purpose
Why not give it a different nature?	Then it would not be a soul. Asking for that is like asking fire to be cold. **Wisdom is for things to be according to their essence**
Why does it suffer?	Its own choices, or suffering for its future good
Isn't the body impure?	**No.** Only emissions are impure; death is the soul's departure

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Chapter 5: Body and Soul Are One Unit

"Chapter 5 is quite short." Saadia emphasises that **body and soul are one unit**, and everything that happens to them in the future happens to them together. "We're going to dwell on this in great detail in the next essay." For Saadia, as for the **Ramban**, **Olam HaBa is *guf* and *nefesh* together**: inseparable in this world and the next. **וייצר ה' אלהים את האדם עפר מן האדמה ויפח באפיו נשמת חיים**: one human being. They are separated for a time at death, which Chapters 6 and 7 will discuss, but they are created together and will receive their bliss together.

Three mistaken views

	Reward and punishment are for…	Their proof
1	**The soul alone**	**נפש כי תחטא**, "a soul that sins"; **הנפש החטאת היא תמות**, "the soul that sins shall die"
2	**The body alone**	**יבוא כל בשר להשתחות לפני**, "all flesh shall come to bow before Me"
3	**The bones alone**	**ותהי עונתם על עצמותם**, "their iniquities are upon their bones" (Yechezkel); **כל עצמותי תאמרנה**, "all my bones shall say"

The third is the view of **Binyamin al-Nahawandi**, a Persian Karaite who lived about a hundred years before Saadia. Chapter 1 met the first Karaite, Anan; the Rabbi named Anan, Binyamin and Shaul as the three famous early Karaites.

Saadia: all three are wrong. Reward and punishment are for **soul and body together**. And all three make the same mistake: **they do not understand how Hebrew is used in Tanach.**

1. **"The soul."** The Torah also says **נפש אשר תגע**, "a soul that touches," and **נפש אשר תאכל**, "a soul that eats." A soul cannot touch or eat. So *nefesh* in such verses means **the whole person**,

body and soul.

2. **"The flesh."** The Torah also says **ויברך כל בשר שם קדשו**, "all flesh shall bless His holy name." Flesh cannot bless without a soul; speech and blessing need the soul. So *basar* too means the whole person.
3. **"The bones."** Binyamin, says Saadia, "is not stupid." In **anatomy** it is true that the skeleton is the main structure of the body and the flesh, sinews and nerves are built around it. But Binyamin knew one cannot carry one discipline into another, Torah into anatomy. His real source was the verses, and **"all my bones shall say"** shows that bones cannot speak; it means **my whole essence**.

Shaul's burial

Binyamin went so far as to say that the people **burnt Shaul's body**. The story: defeated, Shaul fell on his sword after his armour-bearer refused to kill him. The Philistines cut off his head, stripped him and displayed his body. The men of **Yavesh Gilad** risked their lives, came by night, and took the bodies of Shaul and his sons:

ויבאו יבשה וישרפו אתם שם. ויקחו את עצמתיהם ויקברו

They came to Yavesh and **burnt them** there. And they took **their bones** and buried them.

Binyamin read it literally: they burnt the bodies and kept only the bones, "because the bones are the main thing; who cares about the body?"

Saadia rejects this absolutely. **וישרפו אתם** means **they burnt *for* them**: out of respect, they burnt the king's remaining belongings so others would not use them. Compare **ויבך אתו אביו**, "his father wept *him*," which means wept *for* him. And **"bones"** means the person: **הניחו את עצמתי אצל עצמתיו**, "lay my bones beside his bones"; Moshe took **the bones of Yosef**, meaning Yosef himself.

The **Radak**, the Rabbi pointed out, brings both readings as acceptable: that they burnt the beds, belongings and embalming materials out of honour for the king; or, without naming Binyamin, that they burnt the flesh because it had begun to decay and be infested, and out of respect did not bury it in that state. Saadia rejects the second outright.

The five organs of speech

Saadia's principle of Hebrew usage: when something comes from several parts, Scripture will name **one** of them and mean the whole. Speech needs five organs, and the Tanach uses each by itself:

Organ	Verse
פה, mouth	**פי יספר צדקתך**, "my mouth will tell of Your righteousness"
לשון, tongue	**ולשוני תהגה צדקך**, "my tongue will speak of Your righteousness"
שפה, lip	**שפתי ישבחונך**, "my lips will praise You"
חך, palate	**אל חכך שופר**, "to your palate, the shofar"
גרון, throat	**קרא בגרון**, "cry out with the throat"

"Don't tell me that when he calls with his throat he only used his throat." The Rabbi noted the same five sources of speech appear in Hebrew grammar and in the Kabbalah, with different letters coming from different organs; but every letter still needs the whole apparatus.

So too a human being is soul, flesh and bones together. Scripture sometimes says soul, sometimes flesh, sometimes bones, sometimes skin, and means **the whole person**. Even **בביתה לא ישכנו רגליה**, "her feet do not stay in her house": it is not about her feet.

From reason, Scripture and tradition

Saadia has shown from **reason** and from **Scripture** that body and soul are one entity. He ends with **tradition**, the famous **Gemara**:

The soul will say in judgment, it's not my fault, it's the body's; the body will say, it's the soul's. A king had an orchard and set two guards over it, one **lame** and one **blind**. The lame man could not reach the fruit; the blind man could not see it. So the blind man carried the lame man on his shoulders, and together they took the fruit. Each pleaded innocence before the king. But **they did it together, and they are both equally liable**.

So too body and soul: one unit, judged together.

Summary

1. **God does no harm**: people harm from fear, desire or ignorance, none of which applies to Him (Iyov 34:19).
2. **The soul cannot function alone.** Through the body it acts, chooses good, gains light and is refined like silver and gold; while alive, it can always purify itself through teshuvah.
3. **A soul that needs no body would not be a soul**, any more than cold fire. "**True wisdom is for things to be according to their essence**," a line the Rabbi urged for our times.
4. **The body is not inherently impure**: impurity attaches only to emissions, and death is the soul's departure. Contrast the Chassidei Ashkenaz' negation of the body and the Or HaChaim's view of tumah, with its halachic implications for Kohanim.
5. **Body and soul are one unit**, judged and rewarded together. The views that Olam HaBa is for the soul, the body or (with **Binyamin al-Nahawandi**) the bones alone all misread Hebrew, which names one part to mean the whole, as with the five organs of speech, and as in Saadia's reading of Shaul's burial.
6. **The lame and the blind**: tradition confirms what reason and Scripture teach.

Coming Up

Next week, at 6:45: **Chapters 6 and 7**, what happens when the soul leaves the body. The week after: **Chapter 8, reincarnation**, "which is a lot to talk about." Then a break for Pesach.

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